NewsBank inc.

County, state to give restaurants some help

June 30, 2026 | Signal, The (Santa Clarita, CA)
Author: Perry Smith | Section: Business | 619 Words
OpenURL Link

Los Angeles County prides itself on a "world-renowned culinary scene showcasing authentic flavors from virtually every community across the globe" — but breaking into the market can be tough, according to the experts.

Last year, California lawmakers passed a pair of laws, Assembly bills 592 and 671, intending to lower the barriers to entry and "create faster approvals and new options for restaurants looking to cut through red tape," according to comments from a development lobby supporting the legislation.

While California is known for having a relatively strict regulatory business climate, state lawmakers agreed on this problem so much so that both bills passed without a single opposition vote from either party, from the committee process to the governor's signature.

L.A. County is now expected to take a closer look at the legislation, which became effective Jan. 1, with local business owners sharing a similar sentiment to the restaurant lobby, which strongly supported the bills.

"I like it. Anything that streamlines the approval processes is greatly needed," said Greg Amsler, longtime proprietor of Salt Creek Grille at the Valencia Town Center. "Small businesses have been reluctant to do tenant improvements simply due to the amount of regulations that are now required."

Specifically, AB 671 from Assemblywoman Buffy Wicks, D-Oakland, and AB 592, from Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, are intended to streamline the permit process for restaurants, much like Wicks' previous efforts on housing legislation.

AB 671 creates a voluntary expedited path for restaurant tenant improvements. It requires local building departments to allow qualified licensed architects or engineers — at the applicant's expense — to certify that restaurant-renovation plans follow local and state law.

It also establishes timelines for permit reviews, resubmittals and approvals of plans by local building and health departments, with permits issued if the timelines are not met.

AB 592 permanently allows "open kitchens" wherein restaurants can operate with open windows, folding doors, or non-fixed storefronts with a food-safety risk-mitigation plan.

Now, L.A. County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath, who represents the San Fernando Valley, is calling on the county to take a closer look at its practices to make sure it reflects the bill that was signed into law in October.

"As state and local policies change, it is critical that the county provide clear communication and resources to support restaurants in understanding how to comply with updated laws and regulations," according to Horvath's motion.

"Specifically, the report back should include: current process for reviewing and approving restaurant plans, including how new legislative timelines will be met; … financial impacts associated with implementing these policy changes; and the identification of any gaps, challenges, and needed resources to support implementation; and any policy, programmatic or system recommendations to ensure … implementation," according to the agenda for Tuesday's Board of Supervisors meeting.

L.A. County 5th District Supervisor Kathryn Barger said there has to be a balance between a need to streamline

permitting and to keep a watchful eye out for potential violations in food service. She also brought up unpermitted operations, which have been a frequent complaint of Castaic business owners, particularly near Interstate 5.

"Los Angeles County's restaurants and licensed food businesses are vital to our local economy and the communities they serve. We have a responsibility to make it easier for these businesses to succeed by improving education, streamlining permitting and approval processes, and reducing unnecessary barriers to growth," she wrote in a statement Tuesday afternoon, following the board's consent-calendar approval of the item. "At the same time, we must continue to address unpermitted food operations that create an uneven playing field and undermine businesses that are following the law. My focus remains on supporting entrepreneurship while ensuring fairness, public health and consumer confidence."

The post County, state to give restaurants some help appeared first on Santa Clarita Valley Signal.

Copyright, 2026, The Signal. All Rights Reserved.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Smith, P. (2026, June 30). County, state to give restaurants some help*Signal, The (Santa Clarita, CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A912DF77433EFF8.